PART V · HARMONY IN MUSIC · 1

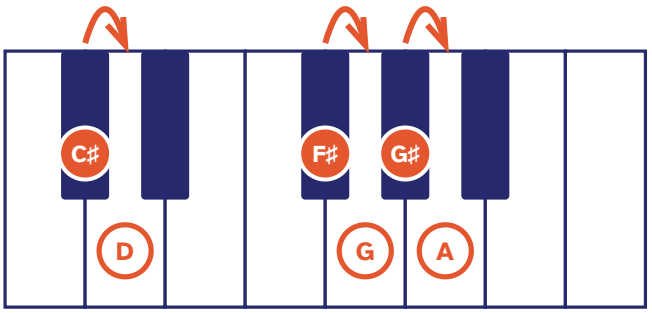
# Chords from outside the key

In C major, home is the white keys, so a black key in a chord is a **guest**. Guests never stay: each one moves to the **very next key** (no key between), and shows you where the music goes next.

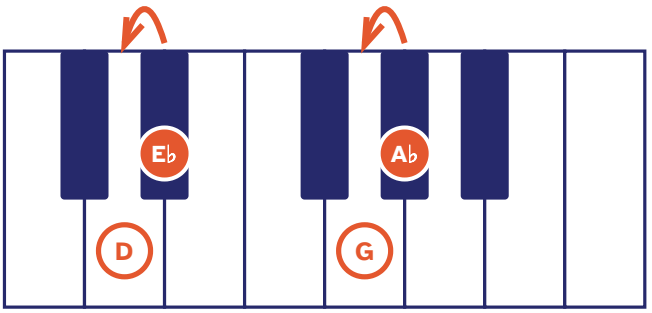
**THE SECRET**

**Sharp guests push up, flat guests sigh down: follow them one key and you find the next chord.**

### Sharp guests push up

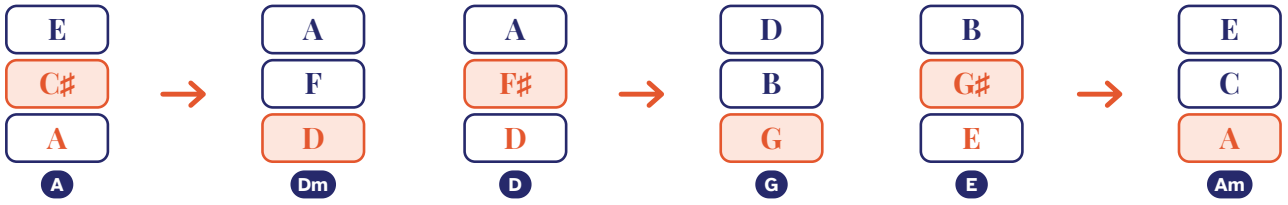



### Flat guests sigh down

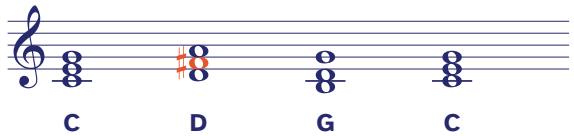



1. Find the **black key** in the chord: that is the guest.
2. A **sharp**? Go **up** to the very next key. A **flat**? Usually **down** to the very next key.
3. You have found a note of the **next chord**. Play it and hear it land.

## Sharp guests: up one key names the next chord

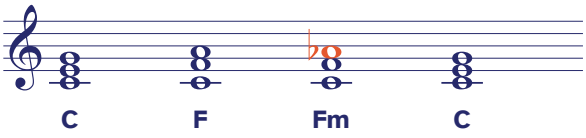



C♯ goes up to **D**, so the next chord is D minor. F♯ goes up to **G**: G. G♯ goes up to **A**: A minor.




Try it in a song: C, D, G, C. The **F♯** pushes up into G, then G leads home to C.

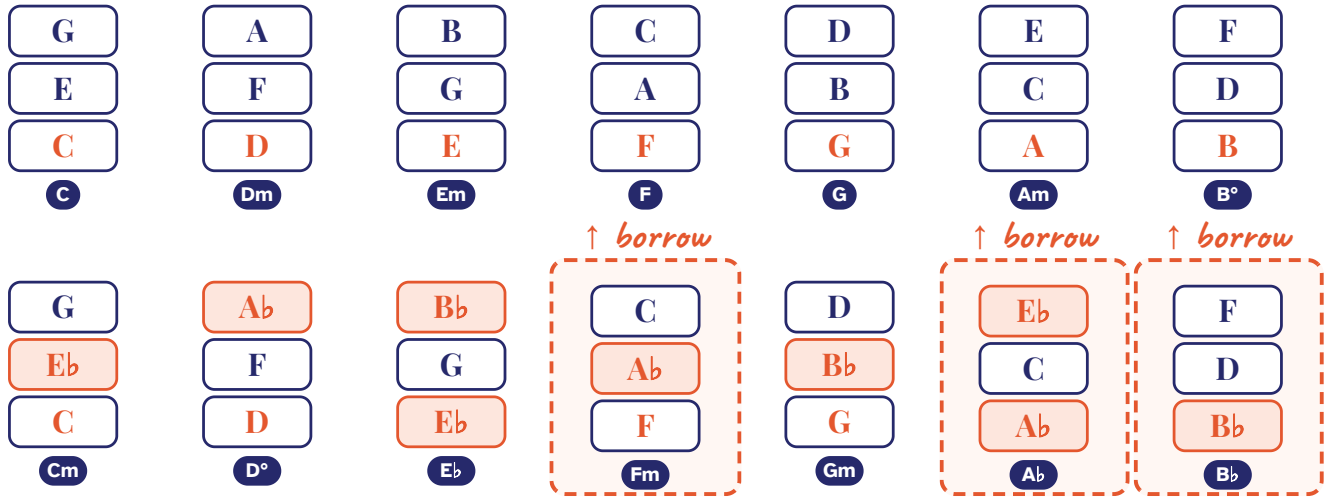
## Flat guests: borrowed from the twin, they sigh down




C major and C minor are **twins** (the parallel minor): the same home note, C, in different clothes. A flat guest is one piece of the twin's outfit. In C, F, Fm, C the **A♭** sighs down to G.

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**C major** *at home*




**C minor** *the twin: same home note, darker clothes*

## Their names, for later

| GUEST | NOTES | MOVES | NEXT CHORD | ITS NAME |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **sharp guest** | D F♯ A | F♯ up to G | G | V of V |
| **sharp guest** | A C♯ E | C♯ up to D | Dm | V of ii |
| **sharp guest** | E G♯ B | G♯ up to A | Am | V of vi |
| **flat guest** | F A♭ C | A♭ down to G | C | borrowed iv |
| **flat guest** | A♭ C E♭ | A♭ down to G | G or C | borrowed ♭VI |
| **flat guest** | B♭ D F | B♭ on to C | C | borrowed ♭VII |

B♭ is the flat guest that walks **up** instead, on to C (one key between: a tone): the rock and film ending B♭ → C.

EXAMPLE

**Where do the guests go? B D♯ F♯ in C major**




1. **Find the black keys:** there are two guests here.
2. **Both are sharps:** move each up to the very next key. Where do they land?
3. **Which cake in C major** holds both landing notes?

D♯ goes up to E, F♯ up to G: both live in **E minor** (E G B). B D♯ F♯ leads to Em.

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GAME

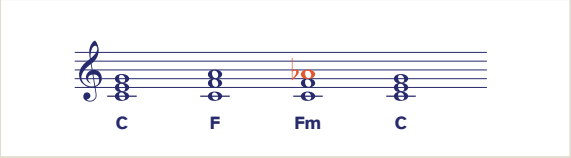
## Where does the guest go?

| 1 | 2 | 3 |
|---|---|---|
| E | E♭ | A |
| C♯ | C | F♯ |
| A | A♭ | D |
| A | A♭ | D |

In C major: find each guest, follow it one key, and write the chord that comes next.

Answer: 1 C♯ up to D: D minor · 2 A♭ down to G, E♭ down to D: G · 3 F♯ up to G: G.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS




### Play C, F, Fm, C slowly.

Hear the A♭ sigh down to G? Now play C, D, G, C: the F♯ pushes up instead. One sighs, one pushes.

THINK OF IT A surprise guest at dinner: one new face changes the whole conversation, and then everyone goes home.

TRAP

- × Following a sharp downwards: sharps push **up**, flats usually sigh **down**.
- × Calling every black key a guest: in G major F♯ is at home. A guest is a note from outside the key you are in.
- × Learning the names first: play it, hear where the guest goes, then name it.
- × Mixing up the relatives: C minor is C major's twin (same home note). A minor is its neighbour (same key signature). We borrow from the twin.

SEE ALSO

Chords in a key p. 93 · Slash chords p. 108 · Cadences p. 116

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 9 · Online: Library › Chromatic chords